

"There neither is, nor can be, any essential difference between the language of prose and metrical composition."

To arrive at this contention, he points out that we have it even in the most elevated kind of poetical passages that reveal an order of words similar to that of prose.

He was against the use of figures, metaphors and similes unnecessarily. He was against the use of artificial poetic diction.

23/08/26 Wordsworth advocated the use of metre in poetry while he rejected the use of poetic diction.

Metre - The rhythm/pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables in a line of poetry.

like beat is a song:

da-DUM | da-DUM

Examples - Iambic metre.

iamb = unstressed + stressed

to-DAY => "to" = weak, "DAY" = strong

He presents use of metre for a number of reasons -

1. Additional source of pleasure. It is pleasure "super added".
2. Appeal to authority and tradition. He points out that people in all ages and countries have acknowledged the charm of metrical language.
3. These are poems on more humble and simpler subjects and simple in language have continued to give pleasure from generation to generation due to use of metre.
4. The end of poetry is to produce emotional excitement. In a state of excitement, ideas and feelings do not follow each other in the accustomed order for which restraint is necessary. Metre has this restraining and tempering effect.
5. Metre is something regular and its use is indispensable when the more pathetic and painful situations have to be rendered.

It has a distancing effect and hence the painful seems remote and so becomes more endurable.

6. Use of metre intermingles an element of pleasure with the painful and so heightens and mitigates it.
7. Metre impart passion to the words and thus enables the poetry to produce the necessary emotional excitement.

Samuel Taylor Coleridge Criticism of Theory of Poetic Diction -

Clarified the many weaknesses -

1. A language so selected and qualified as suggested by Wordsworth would not differ in any way from the language of any other man of commonsense.

After such a selection, there would be no difference between the rustic language used by men in other walks of life.

2. Wordsworth permitted the use of metre, showing a particular arrangement of words. If metre is used, the

arrangement of words in poetry must differ from the metre used in prose but it is different in the poetry of Wordsworth.

3. The use of metre is as artificial as the use of poetic diction. The great Critic asserts that it is absurd to forbid the use of other if one is allowed.
4. Coleridge objected to use of word 'real'. He said that every man's language has, first its individualities; secondly the common properties of the class it belongs to; and thirdly, words and phrases of universal use.
5. It is not correct to say that the best parts of our language are derived from nature. Language is better moulded. As a man advances in thought, he acquires new ideas and concepts which cannot be expressed in rustic language which is primitive and undeveloped.

Thus, Wordsworth's theory of poetic diction is not clear as it should have been. This purpose is sometime defeated by inherent contradiction.

24/08/26

Matthew Arnold - The Study of Poetry, Functions of Criticism

About the writer -

Matthew Arnold (1822-1888)

Era/Age - Victorian Age (1832-1887),
19th Century

Titles - Great Victorian Critic

Admirees - Victorian Scholars, Cultural Critics

Critics - Criticized for moralizing literature

Contribution -

- Developed touchstone method
- Regained poetry as criticism of life
- Promoted objective criticism

The Study of Poetry -

Summary and Context -

This is a critical essay which criticizes the art of poetry as well as the art of criticism. Arnold believes the art of

poetry is capable of high destinies.

He explains why poetry is important and how poetry should be judged. Central argument is great poetry should present a profound and truthful view of life, expressed with beauty and high seriousness, and it can provide moral and emotional guidance to humanity.

What is Poetry - Defines poetry as a "criticism of life".

He says - "In poetry as a criticism of life under the conditions fixed upon such a criticism by the laws of poetic truth and poetic beauty, the spirit of our race will find... as time goes on and as others help fail, its consolation and stay."

4 He said poetry has "immense future" and it is "capable of higher uses". In this way such poetry interprets life, consoles us and sustains us.

4 He explains in this words that poetry as "the noble and profound applications of ideas to life" and "laws of poetic truth and poetic beauty" as "truth and seriousness of subject and

matter' and 'purity and perfection of diction and manner'.

4. True poetry is related to soul of men or to the complete man.

Matthew Arnold Grand Style-

Arnold's Classicism is related to his grand style about which, according to him, the ancients were the "unapproached masters".

4. He regarded Homer as the grand master of grand style.

4. "It arises, in poetry, when a noble nature, poetically gifted, treats with simplicity or severity a serious subject."

4. It has been rightly said, "Arnold's grand style is the same as sublime or longinus".

Four essential elements-

1. The "nobility of soul, your great words issue only from the great minds".
2. "The subject, or action chosen must be

serious enough." It must have the "Touch of substance and high seriousness."

3. "The treatment must be severe or simple". He asserts that must be simple like the style of Homer or severe like that of Milton.

4. Certainly according to Arnold's, "the stylist must be poetically gifted." He added that Homer, Dante and Milton were the great masters of the grand style but other English poets lack such style.

It is necessary to mention that it is the total impression which is important and it certainly leads to grand style.

Standards and Methods of judgement-

He does not prescribe specific features to recognize noble poetry. For this he says that they can be recognised in the poetry of the great poet than in the prose of the critic.

4. "It is much better simply to have recourse to concrete examples; to take specimens of poetry of the high, the very highest quality, and to say:

The characters of a very high quality of poetry are what is expressed there."

- † He further says that the false valuations of the "historic estimate" and "personal estimate" and attain to a "real estimate" by learning to feel and enjoy the best work of the real classic and appreciate the wide difference between it and all lesser works.

The Right Method - Touchstone Method

For distinguishing high poetry from low poetry, he makes use of Touchstone - to keep in one mind lines and expressions of the great masters and to apply them as Touchstone to other practical work.

- † If the other work moves us in the same way as this lines and expression do, then it is really a great work.
- † We should have our own right method to detect the absence or presence of high poetic quality.

The Functions of Criticism at the present time -

Summary and context -

Arnold was not only a critic of literature, he was equally a critic of criticism. In this famous essay he clearly defined and laid down the importance of and role of a critic.

He not only criticised art and literature himself, he also taught others how to criticize them.

Criticism defined - "A disinterested endeavour to learn and propagate the best that is known and thought in the world." - Arnold

It will be seen from this definition that he uses the term criticism in the large sense.

- † Arnold critic is a critic of life, society, religion, culture, national character and all aesthetic activities.
- † "Criticism is not merely judgement in literature" its function is much more

noble, exalted and Catholic."

Depreciation of Criticism not proper -

It is generally believed that Criticism is of lower rank than Creative literature. It may be true to a certain extent but Arnold emphatically says that it is not the whole truth.

1. He did not believe in inherent superiority of the Creative effort of the human spirit over its critical effort.

Importance of Criticism -

For the creation of master work of literature, two powers must concur, the "power of the man" and the "power of the moment".

Criticism helps in the growth of best ideas as well as helpful to future creative writers only by performing its true function.

1. "It is the business of Criticism to know the best that is known and thought in the world, and in its turn by making this known, to create

a current of new and true and fresh ideas" - Arnold

Functions of Criticism -

It is the critic who "discovers" ideas, he who propagates them and nothing remains for the literary genius, but to walk in and undertake the grand work of Synthesis and 'Exposition'.

1. The critic performs another important function as well. He shakes men out of their self-satisfaction and complacency. After this, he directs them towards excellent.

2. Critic must know the best that is known and thought not in literature alone but in other subjects as well.

Task of a Critic -

1. It is the duty of a good critic to learn and understand and "see things as they really are".
2. Transfer his ideas to others to convert the world to "make the best ideas prevail." In this aspect, a good poet and a critic must work like a

missionary.

3. He should also prepare an atmosphere favourable for the Creative genius of the future by developing a "a current of ideas in the highest degree animating and nourishing to the Creative power."

Arnold further says, an ideal critic must spread his noble ideas by stressing upon them again and again to make them popular and practical.

Only in this way, culture may be promoted. It helps the growth of noble ideas for successful creation.

Short-Comings of Matthew Arnold's Criticism -

1. Not Capable of Connecting Reasoning with his Criticism and he often contradicted his own Criticism.

Example - Touchstone method comparing isolated passages for excellence but he also says a poem must be its total impression.

This creates a contradiction - Parts vs the Whole.

2. Criticism lacked logic because he was not a Scientific Critic so he failed to state his views directly and clearly.
3. Arnold wrote as a propagandist as well as a salesman. It is supported by the remark of Wimsatt and Brooks.
4. Criticism lacked in originality because almost all of his ideas are borrowed from the ancients.

Example - "Grand Style" and "High Seriousness" from Aristotle.

"Grand Style" is accordance of "Sublime" of Longinus.

25/08/26

Northrop Frye - The Function of Criticism at the present Time

Summary and Context -

Discusses the purposes and nature of literary criticism. Frye believed criticism should be systematic and scientific study of literature.

He opposed criticism based only on personal likes and dislikes. Criticism should develop objective principles for understanding literature.

About the writer -

Northrop Frye (1912-1991)

Era and Age - Modern age (1890-1950), 20th Century

Titles - Father of Archetypal Criticism

Admirers - Structuralists, literary theorists

Critics - Criticized for being too systematic

Contribution -

- Developed Archetypal Criticism
- Studied Myths and Symbols
- Made Criticism more Scientific

The Function of Criticism at the Present Time -

Definition of Criticism -

"An art based on pre-existing art, a second-hand initiation of creative power."

Function of Criticism -

1. Mediation between the artist and his public -

"One obvious function of Criticism is to mediate, between the artist and his public."

"Criticism exists because it can talk, and all arts are dumb."

- * Criticism of a literary text works out properly by exposing the hidden meaning and sorting out every detail of the work.

2. Popularity of Writers - Depends very much upon the critical evaluation of their works and the skill of a critic play a very dominant role.

"Shakespeare was more popular than Webster but not because he was a greater dramatist — But after a critic who had been at work for a while —"

3. Role and Types of Critic - Critic has a specific field of activity, and that he has autonomy within that field.

The critic ought to be rational and logical in his approach.

"Literally works are also for the critic more complex of facts, like the data of science."

The autonomous organizing of literature may be criticism according to Frye and that deals with literature in terms of a specific conceptual framework.

Types of Critics -

1. Critical reader - Who faces the public

2. Critic proper - Completely involved in literary values as the poet himself.

4. Examining literature - In terms of a conceptual framework which is derived from an inductive survey of an literary field.

"We should examine the containing forms of criticism including the poet's life, his historical context, his language and his thought to see whether the critic can impose a unified critical form on this things without giving place to or turning into a biographer, an historian, a philologist or a philosopher."

5. Genes Conception & Classification - The coherent conception of genes is one of the important condition on the part of the critic and his function is to derive different levels of meaning in literature and then defining as well as classifying.

it.

* If the Critic work in this manner then the work produced becomes a part of 'higher Criticism' otherwise merely editing of texts and collecting of relevant texts remains a work on surface level and thus is a part of 'lower Criticism'.

* The Criticism still has to develop a theory of literature in this way, says Iyer and "to begin this process" seems to him "The function of Criticism at the present time".